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East-West
15 October 2020

A Cross Cultural Examination of Balance

I. Introduction

Balance. Order. Chaos. These ideas are universal in many cultures across time. The first time I was introduced to this topic was my sophomore year in high school in my world history class when we learned about Buddhism and the Middle Way. As I gained more knowledge of different culture's philosophy and religions, the idea of balancing order and chaos seemed to pop up everywhere, so one must beg the question: Why? How have many cultures come to the same conclusion without having interacted with each other? Is there some biological mechanism that made this idea inherent to humans? Through an investigation of physiology and neurophysiology, it is clear to see why the idea of balancing order and chaos persists in almost every culture. From early Ancient Chinese philosophers to modern-day psychologists, this archetype exists and presents itself in different ways, and it is because balancing order and chaos in our own brain is the key to expanding our mental capacity and reaching the enlightenment that both the ancient Greeks and the ancient Chinese hinted at.

II. Balance in Eastern Culture

When I think about balance in eastern philosophy, Buddhism and Daoism come to mind; however, the idea of balance is also present in Confucianism and Hinduism. Buddhism's balance is found in their concept of the Middle Way. The texts suggest that everyone should live a life

that's in between true asceticism and extreme indulgence (Freiberger). A quote from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta explains the Middle Way perfectly:

“There is addiction to indulgence of sense-pleasures, which is low, coarse, the way of ordinary people, unworthy, and unprofitable; and there is addiction to self-mortification, which is painful, unworthy, and unprofitable.

Avoiding both these extremes, the Tathagata (The Perfect One) has realized the Middle Path; it gives vision, gives knowledge, and leads to calm, to insight, to enlightenment and to Nibbana.” (Translated by Thera)

In summary, the two extremes, addiction to indulgence and self-mortification, are non-productive and following the Middle Path will give you knowledge and enlightenment. In my perspective, order is indulgence and chaos is self-mortification. When we indulge ourselves, we are usually doing it in a way that creates more safety and order in our lives. Asceticism leads to many uncertainties because it is harder to control life when you don't have access to your daily self-pleasures. Buddhism suggests that being in the Middle Way gives you enlightenment, and the Buddha's perspective is totally valid given the fact that he experienced both sides of the spectrum. I believe he came to the conclusion that sheltering yourself from suffering will just make you ignorant, even if you have more order in your life, and the chaos he felt when he experienced suffering for the first time gave him more insight.

By contrast, Daoism and Confucianism give a different perspective on the same idea. They have the concept of the yin and yang. The Han Confucian Dong Zhongshu writes “the entire Dao between Heaven and Earth culminates in the beauty of harmony”. Chenyang Li further elaborates in *The Philosophy of Harmony in Classical Confucianism* by saying,

“Harmony is the right path of Heaven and the balance between the yin and the yang. When the yin and the yang are balanced, the energy (qi) flows well and things get generated” (Li). It’s quite fascinating to see harmony as a concept in ancient Chinese philosophy because it is also explained as a path, just like in Buddhism. Instead of using indulgence and asceticism as two extremes of the spectrum, it uses Heaven and Earth. One could make the connection between Heaven and indulgence because Heaven is a conceptual place where everything is good. Earth and asceticism can be connected because when you have nothing to indulge in, you just have nature, which is chaotic. This is interesting primarily because the same idea manifested itself in the two cultures as two separate ideas.

III. Balance in Western Culture

Switching to western culture, the ancient Greeks developed this idea of the golden mean which presents their take on order and chaos. Samuel Douglass explains in his article, “his ‘golden mean’ philosophy suggests that the ideal point along a trait continuum represents an intermediate level that exceeds a lower value (i.e., a vice of deficiency) and falls short of higher value (i.e., a vice of excess)” (Douglass and Tay). Here is another idea of balance, though there is not yet an obvious connection to order and chaos, and this doesn’t explain what ideal means. Ideal for what purpose? Making an interesting point of clarification, Stanley Cunningham of University of Windsor claims that when Aristotle proposed this metaphorical golden mean, he didn’t suggest that one could search the middle of two extremes and find some absolute truth. Cunningham explains, “In the Golden Mean conception, however, the extremes emerge as conceptually prior to the mean because they become the primary (and in the more truncated accounts, the only) determinants of median goodness: One arrives at the midpoint by first

perceiving or envisaging extremes, avoiding them and negotiating a passage between them.

This, however, reverses what Aristotle had in mind when he talked about virtue in terms of excellence and rightness” (Cunningham S). The difference is that he suggests that truth itself defines the middle of a spectrum and the definition of extremes comes secondary to that. It’s a nuanced difference, but a striking one. Compare that to Eastern thought, where they seem to suggest that one reaches enlightenment by negotiating between two extremes and following that path. The main difference, though, is that Aristotle claims that the golden mean exists first, and then the spectrum, with the extremes at both ends, is created centered around the golden mean.

Another important idea of western thought comes from Judeo-Christian beliefs. Just take the concept of the Garden of Eden. You start out with nature, which is very characteristically chaotic. What happens if you add order to nature? You get a garden. In this garden, there is the tree of the knowledge of good and evil (*New American Bible*, Genesis 2:9). I think that the knowledge of good and evil connects perfectly back to the concept of order and chaos. The story makes me realize that the meaning of life comes from the struggles and burdens we endure. Just being born, we have to endure the burden that one day we will die, and that concept just by itself gives us an incentive to live before we die. This, I believe, makes a much more profound and deeper claim to order and chaos. There would be no meaning to life if it was all order, and our meaning to life derives from our chase for chaos. Or rather, we can find meaning to life if we find a burden worth bearing, and we bear it. According to the Judeo-Christian faith, we will not only be enlightened, we will become empowered to be independent like Adam and Eve became after eating from the tree of good and evil. It is similar to the golden mean because enlightenment (the truth) came first, then came the extreme of chaos to fight the order that was created by God.

IV. Similarities between Cultures

In order to form a coherent sense of how science connects all of these cultures together, I think it would be wise to reconcile the similarities between the cultures. It can be observed that all of these cultures are trying to present the same idea; however, the idea is so complex that they use different abstractions to convey the information. In general, they all say that having too much order leaves us stagnant and when you introduce chaos to balance the order, you will grow. To conceptualize these abstractions, I think you can make it as concrete as a mathematical formula to observe the similarities.

Buddhism: Indulgence + Asceticism = (a path to) Enlightenment

Daoism/Confucianism: Yin + Yang = (a path to) Heaven + Creation

Ancient Greek philosophy: Truth $\rightarrow$ Two extremes

Judeo-Christianity: Knowledge $\rightarrow$ Burden, Order + Burden = Empowerment + Meaning

(I'm using $\rightarrow$ to show creation of. For example, Truth $\rightarrow$ two extremes means the ancient Greeks believed the truth created two extremes in which the truth was at the center of it)

In the next section, I will show that the same formula can be seen in our own biology and our formation of thoughts.

Ideas: Abstraction + Conceptualization = Complexity

Learning: Known + Unknown/Error = Growth in knowledge

V. The Expression of Order and Chaos in Biology

We looked at literature, movies, and art in class, and I think that these fall in a spectrum. these are different mediums in which we can express ideas. I think on the extreme order side of

the spectrum, we have mathematics. We can express many concepts using math, a seemingly infinite amount of concepts; however, it also seems to me that it isn't possible to explain every concept using math, especially the more abstract or complex ones. On the other end of the spectrum, I believe we have dreams. While we don't use dreams to express ideas to other people, our subconscious uses dreams to express ideas to our conscious mind. In my opinion, dreams express ideas too complex to comprehend with the conscious mind. We dream multiple times a night, yet we hardly even remember our dreams. The fact that we can dream is already bizarre, considering that it means that we don't always do our own thinking; there is another part of our brain that does thinking for us and gives us things like dreams, without our own doing. Chaotic, indeed. To quickly clarify, I want to note that in between dreams and math, we have mediums that are in the middle of chaotic and orderly. There's abstract art, then music, then poetry, then literature, then cinema, then research articles. It's not always necessarily in that order, but they definitely fall in the spectrum of mediums. Carl Jung is a commonly cited psychoanalyst when it comes to dreams. Jung suggested that dreams are formed unconsciously by a process trying to connect everything we know by forming a narrative whose meaning might surface to the conscious level at any point in time (Cunningham L and Bradway). How is it possible that our mind can create stories with meanings that we don't know or come to conclusions before we come to those conclusions, at least consciously? This seems to be good psychological evidence that there is a dichotomy between order and chaos in our brain, which can be seen by looking at the right and left hemispheres of the brain.

Brain function is lateralized between the two hemispheres (Newman). This means that the two hemispheres, even though they're seemingly identical, specialize in specific tasks over the other. The dominance of each hemisphere on specific tasks can give us insight on the primary

functions of each hemisphere. For example, a study done on patients with panic disorder found that they had more activity in the right hemisphere of their brain (Smeets et al.). This makes sense because the right hemisphere is commonly associated with creativity, and creativity is chaotic and unknown which would help anyone in a state of panic create solutions, or rather, they wouldn't be in a state of panic if everything was orderly. To further develop my point, a clinical trial supported the proposition that the right hemisphere of the brain is far superior in anomaly detection than the left one (Smith et al.). I believe this is crucial to the idea of balance of order and chaos. Without the ability to detect anomalies, we wouldn't learn anything. To recap, the left hemisphere of the brain holds the power of order by understanding the world through a logical lens and the right hemisphere helps us build knowledge by being creative and detecting anomalies. In the book *The World is Flat*, Thomas Friedman further clarifies the functions of the left and right hemispheres and emphasizes the importance of both in today's world. He says,

“The left hemisphere handles sequence, literalness, and analysis. The right hemisphere, meanwhile, takes care of context, emotional expression, and synthesis . . . Until recently, the abilities that led to success in school, work, and business were characteristic of the left hemisphere. They were the sorts of linear, logical, analytical talents measured by SATs and deployed by CPAs. Today, those capabilities are still necessary. But they're no longer sufficient. In a world upended by outsourcing, deluged with data, and choked with choices, the abilities that matter most are now closer in spirit to the specialties of the right hemisphere—artistry, empathy, seeing the big picture, and pursuing the transcendent”(Friedman, 321)

Overall, balancing order and chaos isn't exclusive to ancient philosophy, but is also applicable to our modern-day society. This is because it's directly tied to how our brain functions, and society is built to reflect how humans work.

My professor, Dr. Jungck, a theoretical biologist with doctorates in Evolution and Molecular and Cellular Biology, further elaborates on the importance of chaos in learning. In his paper, *Ignorance, Error, and Chaos: Local Learning/Global Research*, he divides ignorance, error, and chaos as three different things, and further dissects ignorance into a tree of things. For simplicity's sake, I will refer to them all as anti-order. Jungck presents his case on using these elements of anti-order to fully maximize the efficiency of learning. Ignorance leads scientists to pose questions. Error leads us to learn from our mistakes. Chaos forces students to self-assess and reorganize (Jungck). All three are forces of anti-order that disrupt our comfortable, orderly states and push us from stagnancy to growth. In a short exchange with my professor, he claims to take order and chaos from a different angle; it seems to me that, much like the differing abstractions of that idea of eastern and western cultures, he has just made the same observation but presents it differently, using a different equation.

VI. Conclusion

In summary, balancing order and chaos presents itself in multiple ways across cultures and time in religion, philosophy, and science. The omnipresence of it is related to how our brain functions and how balancing order and chaos leads to an outcome of maximum growth of knowledge. Through observation, I believe many cultures recognized this pattern and created different abstractions (enlightenment, Heaven, yin, yang) to try to explain the pattern they

recognized. What they were observing was the fact that when our brain encounters chaos and anomalies, the right hemisphere detects it. Working together with the left hemisphere, our brain learns by updating the left hemisphere's logical expectations to fit the anomalies detected by the right hemisphere. This dynamic has created the importance of creativity, art, and chaos in our society, education, and life as a whole.

VII. An Afterword: Balancing Order and Chaos in my East-West class

A biological dependence on balance relates a lot with the class. Throughout the class, we found great insight into other cultures through literature, movies, art, and calendars. I believe we are finding different mediums because the examination of culture is very complex, and you can't just explain culture with cut-and-dried explanatory essays. Culture has to be lived and experienced. The usage of more abstract and chaotic mediums give the artist a more complex way to express their culture in which we can use the balance between our left and right hemispheres to not fully comprehend but fully sense the differences between cultures. Even when we do powerpoints in class, I am definitely more comfortable developing an idea if I can use visual aids, especially compared to writing an essay to portray an idea. In our class, we have engineers, artists, designers, dreamers, writers, and many more types of thinkers than can be listed, all with different proportions of order and chaos driving their thinking, and when given the proper media, we can present our complex thoughts to an audience. Afterall, even the greatest philosophers needed to make abstractions to portray the complex idea of balance.

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